LOOKING FOR MOLLY
OR
I'M NOT EXACTLY PROUD OF WHAT MY LIFE HAS BECOME

Written by

Hunter Hawke

hunter@accipiterpictures.com

INT. DOC KIMBALL'S HOUSE / PAUL'S ATTIC BEDROOM - NIGHT

PAUL KIMBALL, a pornsick twenty-something, sits on his bed, LAPTOP resting in his lap. Discord is open to a messages tab with someone named "PusillanimousDimple69."

The messages descending down the screen all from Paul:

3:14 PM "Where have you been?" - Seen

3:14 PM "I miss my little boo" - Seen

3:15 PM "We need to chill IRL again soon" - Seen

3:16 PM "Sneak by the house soon pweetty pweez" - Seen

3:20 PM "Oh am I being too sub for you?" - Seen

3:21 PM "You want me to manhandle you? Take the kiddie gloves off?" - Seen

3:21 PM "I will absolutely ruin you" - Unread

3:21 PM "I'll slap and choke you and fill every last hole of yours with my seed"

3:22 PM "Until you're begging on your knees to be put back in the closet for next time"

3:23 PM "Yeah that's right. I just keep you in the closet"

3:24 PM "Like a vacuum"

3:24 PM "You're literally my personal fuck doll. I can use you whenever I want"

Paul stares at the screen, then buries his face in his hands.

He drags the mouse to HIGHLIGHT all of the unread messages.

Then clicks the TRASH CAN ICON.

An alert pops up: "Do you want to delete these messages for Penelope too?"

He drags the cursor over "YES."

CLICK

Then click-clacks on the keyboard to spit out one more message:

5:59 PM "Penelope?"

Paul opens up a new browser tab and types into the search engine “Role Call.”

Clicks the first result.

He clicks on the “18+ Chat” button.

The website prompts him to input a display name.

He types: “M20 LF dirty talk, a sweet girl who likes to be naughty.”

START.

And he’s in! The computer shows him live feed after live feed of eighteen to seventy-six-year-old guys masturbating *a la Omegle*.

Some position the webcam close up on their junk.

Some lay out showing the length of their bodies.

Some guys’ faces are cut out of frame.

Others only show their faces.

Flaccid, erect, circumcised, uncircumcised--every flavor, shape and size.

SKIP, SKIP, SKIP.

Paul picks his shoulder off the pillow and sits up against the head board. Brushes his hair up with his hand how it naturally wants to part.

Then a WOMAN *does* appear on the screen...

Only to skip him immediately.

He goes back to the Discord tab. No new messages. Drums his fingers on the side of the computer.

Back to Role Call.

Naked dude, naked dude, naked dude.

ANOTHER WOMAN! This one covered in makeup and dressed in a bikini, windowless basement apartment behind her. Only this time instead of skipping, she types:

“Hey, I can make sexy time for you if you venmo.”

Paul sighs. Hovers over the skip button. Covers his eyes.

Click.

And then a voice:

MOLLY (O.S.)
What are you doing covering your face, silly?

He takes his hand away from his face.

On the screen is MOLLY, a cute, petite girl with long, brown hair, a pink shirt and a choker around her neck.

MOLLY (CONT'D)
Finally, a guy who's not just already masturbating.

PAUL
Already?

MOLLY
I mean, I want to do at least a little encouraging first.

Paul laughs.

PAUL
I don't know what to say.

MOLLY
How about your name?

PAUL
Um, Jake.

MOLLY
It's nice to meet you, Jake! I'm Molly. So what's your story? Why are you on here?

PAUL
Are you even eighteen?

Molly laughs.

MOLLY
Funny you should ask. Oh my god this is gonna sound so cliché it's ridiculous, but--

More laughter.

PAUL
What? You're not, are you?

MOLLY
Hey! I am! I am! I was gonna say I just turned eighteen yesterday.

PAUL
Really?

MOLLY
Really, really.

PAUL
You're lying!

MOLLY
No, I'm not.

PAUL
You just turned eighteen yesterday? What are you doing on this website?

MOLLY
Looking for someone to celebrate with me.

PAUL
You're funny.

MOLLY
Aw, thanks!

PAUL
Happy birthday.

MOLLY
Thanks! So how old are *you*, Jake?

PAUL
I'm twenty.

MOLLY
You look older.

PAUL
A lot of people tell me that.

MOLLY
Hey, it's okay. I like older. I've always been more curious about older guys. Their more fully developed bodies.

PAUL
So what do you like to do?

Paul creeps a SCREENSHOT of Molly.

MOLLY
What do you mean?

PAUL
Like what things do you do in your life right now? Do you work?

MOLLY
I'm in high school. So mostly finishing up high school, yeah.

PAUL
Ah, senior year?

MOLLY
Senior year.

PAUL
Are you going to college next year?

MOLLY
What's with all this small talk?

PAUL
What do you mean?

MOLLY
You know what I mean.

PAUL
Is it a crime to want to know more about who I'm talking to?

MOLLY
This website is for strangers. It's called Role Call. You're supposed to make up someone who's not you and be that person.

PAUL
Okay, well do that then. Just make up answers.

MOLLY
I'm in a lot of clubs at school.

PAUL
Yeah, what clubs?

MOLLY
I'm in a dick sucking club.

PAUL
What?!

Molly bursts out laughing.

MOLLY
You should've seen your face!

PAUL
C'mon be realistic. Pretend to be honest with me.

MOLLY
Okay. Why do you need to know me so bad anyway?

PAUL
I guess I like it better when it feels real.

Molly smiles.

PAUL (CONT'D)
Was it actually your birthday yesterday?

MOLLY
It was actually my birthday.

PAUL
And you're really eighteen.

MOLLY
Really, really.

PAUL
I like the way you are so much.

MOLLY
(beaming)
What do you mean?

PAUL
I like the way you talk. I like the way you look. I don't know. I like your whole..vibe.

MOLLY
Aw, you're like the sweetest guy I've met on here.

PAUL
Am I too sweet? Does that make you like me less?

MOLLY
No! Of course not.

PAUL
Some girls don't like sweet in a guy.

MOLLY
I like sweet. You're like a real person. It's hot.

She winks at him.

PAUL
You're hot.

MOLLY
I know.

Paul breathes heavy.

PAUL
Molly?

MOLLY
Yeah, Jake?

PAUL
I want to say something I really shouldn't.

MOLLY
Go ahead.

Paul starts rubbing his dick through his pants in small motions he takes care to keep invisible to the webcam.

MOLLY (CONT'D)
C'mon, I've heard it all. There's nothing you're gonna say to upset me.

PAUL
Molly, I want to do bad things to you.

MOLLY
Yeah? What kinds of things?

PAUL
I want to slap your ass and call you a slut.

MOLLY
Yeah? Can I be a bad little slut for you?

PAUL
I want to rip off your clothes and, and...are you sure you're okay with this?

MOLLY
I want you to use me! How do you want to use me?

PAUL
I want to use your whore face for my cock.

MOLLY
Mmm, I like that. How do you want to do that?

PAUL
I want you to deepthroat me. Can you do that for me, Molly?

MOLLY
I'd love to. I'm a giver.

PAUL
You like to give?

MOLLY
Mhm.

PAUL
I like to take.

MOLLY
Is there anything else you want to take from me, Jake?

PAUL
I want your whole body. I want to thrust into your dripping pussy until you're moaning in ecstasy.

MOLLY
Thinking of having your hard dick inside of me makes me so wet.

PAUL
Oh my god.

MOLLY
Fuck me, Jake. Fuck me hard!

PAUL
Holy fuck. Can you look me in the eyes? I mean, look at the camera.

Molly shifts her eyes to the camera, staring straight through the screen to him.

MOLLY
Put your cock deep inside me.

PAUL
Oh my god, that's so powerful. It's hard through the internet like this, but you're making it feel really real.

MOLLY
Yeah? You know why?

PAUL
Why?

MOLLY
It's because I really want it!

PAUL
Oh my god!

Paul strokes.

MOLLY
Are you hard for me?

Paul nods his head.

MOLLY (CONT'D)
I want you to pull it out and show me.

A formidable, low bellow in a WOMAN'S VOICE from below, marching up the stairs outside:

DOC (O.S.)
Paul! What are you doing? Aren't you going to join us?!

PAUL
Wait, don't come in! I'm changing!

In one swift keyboard shortcut, Paul closes the BROWSER WINDOW. Then shuts his eyes hard and grits his teeth.

The door rumbles.

PAUL (CONT'D)
I said, don't come in!

Paul jostles his junk back in and zips his pants quickly.

DOC (O.S.)
Oh, why? You're not decent? What are you doing up here?

PAUL
I'm changing.

DOC (O.S.)
Will you join us in a minute? Everyone's down here having a good time.

PAUL
Yeah, alright.

DOC (O.S.)
What?

PAUL
Yes! Just go away. I need privacy.

DOC (O.S.)
We're about to eat. Everyone's waiting on you!

PAUL
I'm coming! Okay? Just give me a minute.

DOC (O.S.)
Alright.

Footsteps descend.

Paul tries reopening the browser window.

Naked dude, naked dude, naked dude...

His lips curl downward as he grabs at his hair, then rams his fist into his head.

PAUL
Fuck!

New Discord notification:

From PusillanimousDimple69, “Ik, I miss you too. I’ll come by soon for sure. Has been too long. Just been busy <3”

Paul feels his limp dick through his pants.

Navigates to the desktop.

Opens the screenshot of Molly big on his screen.

CUT TO:

INT. DOC KIMBALL’S HOUSE / DINING ROOM - DAY

A family seated around a table.

Two wives, DOC (F, 53) and ROSIE (F, 43)--the slighter, more feminine of the pair, where Doc is more stringent, direct jewess matriarch.

One of Rosie’s OVEN MITTS graces the BUFFET. The other is sandwiched between the dining table and a steaming vessel of CHEESY POTATOES.

The table is further amply adorned with CREAMED SPINACH, SAUSAGE ROLLS, and in the center, a beautifully carved, ROAST CHICKEN. They’re sitting down to a feast.

PLATES almost full now as people take their helpings.

DOC
So of course it didn’t surprise me at all that my daughter was a lesbian.

LEXIE (F, 27), cloaked in a BRIGHT PINK BOA, shoots her a death glare.

DOC (CONT’D)
Anyway!

ROSIE
Well, um, bon appétit.

DOC
Or as I like to say, simply, dig in!

Plates full, everyone eats at their own pace. Paul lifts his fork with the weight of a depressed person, every now and again stealing glances across the way to CAMILLE (F, 25), who wears a nice, WHITE BLOUSE, almost tastefully containing her noticeable cleavage.

Camille sits closely with Lexie, leaning over to her shoulder periodically.

CAMILLE
(under her breath, to Lexie)
...May have had just a little too much to drink.

LEXIE
(quietly)
It’s okay. I’m here, babe.

CHRIS (M, 11) stuffs his face. UNCLE JASON (M, 47) sits beside him, coaching Chris with his hands and facial expressions on how to properly handle silverware.

JASON
(sotto)
No, not like that, Chris. Hold it like it’s a utensil.

ROSIE
Well, there should be something for everyone.

CAMILLE
The food is amazing! Thank you Mrs. Kimball! You’re a wonderful chef!

ROSIE
Oh, you’re too kind. And you can just call me Rosie, honey.

CAMILLE
Oh, okay. Rosie, what a lovely name! I guess that makes it less confusing because otherwise you’re both Mrs. Kimball?

UNCLE JASON
Well, actually, Rosie kept her last name--

DOC
No, I would be Dr. Kimball. If we were using honorifics. But you can just call me..Doc!

Doc cracks a smile.

CAMILLE
Ah, doc.

DOC
Yeah, that's what they call me.

CAMILLE
What are you a doctor of?

DOC
Psychiatry.

PAUL
Hey, if it quacks like a doctor, it's a doctor.

Doc gives Paul a good kick under the table.

Camille struggles to contain a laugh. A cute little snort comes out. She covers her face.

CAMILLE
Excuse me.

She smiles at Paul.

DOC
Isn't it nice we can all be here together?
(to Lexie)
You know, I invited your father. He just decided not to show up, I guess.

LEXIE
Mom.

DOC
Well, I'm just saying, he had an open invitation.

PAUL
Wouldn't it be fucking great if Dad just waltzed in here. Buncha strangers.
(imitating with a cartoon voice)
Hey, my daughter's girlfriend who I'm meeting for the first time? How do you like my ex-wife's wife's cooking who I'm also meeting for the first time?

Camille spits out her food and bursts into uncontrollable laughter, turning to Lexie.

CAMILLE
Is that what his voice is like?

DOC
What on God's earth?

CAMILLE (CONT'D)
(crying, laughing)
I'm sorry!

LEXIE
She can't help it sometimes.

CAMILLE
I don't. I didn't mean to--

She catches her breath, cleans off her shirt with a cloth napkin.

CAMILLE (CONT'D)
Whew, I'm so sorry.

PAUL
You're adorable is what you are! Lexie, you need to bring her around more often.

LEXIE
Alright, Paul. Don't be a creep.

PAUL
What! For saying I enjoy your girlfriend's company?

CAMILLE
It's fine. He's nice.

PAUL
It's simple polite conversation.
(to Camille)
I like your company. It's nice when you're around.

LEXIE
Right. 'Cause you're the king of polite, non-awkward conversation. Right, Paul?

CAMILLE
It's okay.
(to Paul)
I like your company too. Your jokes are funny.

Doc turns her nose up.

DOC
However irreverent, I suppose.

Paul turns to Uncle Jason.

PAUL
Jason, I like your company. It’s nice having you here for the holidays.

UNCLE JASON
Ahh, likewise, but can we keep it “Uncle Jason” in front of this one?

Uncle Jason gestures to Chris.

Paul turns to Rosie.

PAUL
Love you, Rosie. I’m glad we’re here together.

Rosie returns a sweet, genuine smile.

Chris scrunches up his little face.

ROSIE
You know how to make anyone feel special, don’t you?

CHRIS
I also love you, Mommy!

ROSIE
Okay, can you just call me mom, honey? Remember, like we said?

CHRIS
But why?

ROSIE
Eleven is a little old to still be saying, “Mommy.”

Chris looks down. Lights up his E-READER under the table.

The screen displays the title of a volume in large, centered font: “Meditations on a Deterministic Universe.”

He taps the back button and clicks on a different book with a shorter title: “Bad Words.”

A list of bad words with their corresponding definitions comes up on the screen: “Bastard - a child born out of wedlock, Bitch - a female dog, etc.”

CAMILLE
It would be great to meet your Dad at some point, of course! Even though it couldn’t happen tonight.

PAUL
But to answer your question, that’s how he talks. I do a dead-on impression of dad, wouldn’t you say, Lexie?

LEXIE
Flawless.

Paul looks back to Camille.

Winks.

She smiles. Hiccups.

CAMILLE
So what do you do, Rosie?

ROSIE
I’m an ornithologist.

INT. DOC KIMBALL’S HOUSE / THE DOCTORS’ STUDY - NIGHT

Paul stands over Camille at a coffee table, pointing down at a BOOK OF BIRDS.

Camille sips a CAN OF GINGER ALE.

PAUL
The teal-ribbed falcon.

CAMILLE
It says teal-winged.

PAUL
That’s what I meant.

CAMILLE
This is what you wanted to show me?

PAUL
Yeah.

CAMILLE
Let’s get back to the living room with everyone.

PAUL
Okay, no. There was something else I wanted to tell you.

CAMILLE
Okay.

PAUL
Marry my sister.

Camille laughs.

CAMILLE
Paul, what?!

PAUL
Marry, my sister. I can see you two are happy together. I don’t know how it works with lesbian couples, but she’s not going to make the first move on this.

CAMILLE
We’ve barely been dating a full year.

PAUL
We’ve got a good thing going--

CAMILLE
Lexie’s great, but we’re--

PAUL
--so just marry her. Then we can do this every year.

CAMILLE
We are not having this conversation right now.

PAUL
Camille! Marry my sister!

CAMILLE
You’re relentless.

PAUL
Please. For me.

CAMILLE
For you?

PAUL
Yeah! Do it for me.

CAMILLE
If I'm marrying anyone I'm doing it only for me and that person as a matter of principle.

PAUL
That makes sense. Good rule of thumb. It's only in this very particular instance that you could do it for me too.

CAMILLE
What? Why? What are you talking about?

PAUL
Well, then we can keep this whole thing going.

CAMILLE
We?

PAUL
You and me.

CAMILLE
What thing?

PAUL
You think I don't know what's going on here?

CAMILLE
Paul, if you think you and *I* have a thing, I'm sorry, but you're sorely mistaken. I barely fucking know you.

PAUL
Oh, keep negging me. I love it.

CAMILLE
Negging you?

PAUL
C'mon, Camille! Camille, no one gives a shit.
(MORE)

PAUL (CONT'D)
I don't think Lexie would care if you told her outright.

CAMILLE
I don't know what you're talking about.

PAUL
There's no shame in it! I enjoy it.

CAMILLE
Enjoy what? Enjoy me *negging* you?

PAUL
Oh, c'mon, Camille. Don't be so daft. This is the third time we're aggressively flirting with each other somewhere where you're with my sister and I'm third-wheeling. I want to do this at every family gathering. Just dance around this tension and do nothing about it. We can keep this going until we're ninety. I mean, I could get used to that.

Camille smiles wide.

CAMILLE
Right.

PAUL
Like an old friend. It feels that way already, doesn't it?

CAMILLE
If you say so.

Paul dances up to her quickly. She puts her hands out to stop him, and he presses his palms against hers.

PAUL
Like maybe we knew each other in a past life.

Camille pushes his hands away.

CAMILLE
Respectfully, Paul, you're an idiot.

PAUL
Yes, please! More! More, please!

CAMILLE
No, no more.

PAUL
I'm your idiot. Your girlfriend's sexy idiot of a brother who's crazy about you.

CAMILLE
On second thought, you're of average intelligence, and I don't mean to insult you in any way shape or form.

PAUL
Yeah, that's right. I'm even more unspecial than that. I'm just average. Forgettable. I'm no idiot savant.

CAMILLE
I never said you were a savant!

PAUL
And I'm sure not. I'm just some average sucker. Tit sucker. Tit sucker, I wish! Not fit to lick your fucking boot heel.

Camille stands.

CAMILLE
I think I'm gonna go back to the living room. I'm sure your family would like for you to join them too.

PAUL
Camille!

CAMILLE
What?!

Paul leans in to kiss Camille.

Camille jolts her head away and runs to the door.

CAMILLE (CONT'D)
Get off me you fucking psychopath!

Paul drops to his knees.

PAUL
Please, spare me your cruelty! Fairest maiden of the highest tower.

CAMILLE
Shut up, shut up, shut up!

PAUL
(inventing)
Dost thou needs't thy hand swept in marriage--?

CAMILLE
Stop talking right now!

That moment, Lexie opens the study door.

LEXIE
Hey guys, we're about to eat dessert. Oh, was Paul showing you the bird book?

Lexie steps inside the study.

CAMILLE
Yeah?

PAUL
Showing her the steel-ribbed falcon.

Lexie glances down at it for a beat.

LEXIE
Cool.
(to Paul)
Care to rejoin us?

PAUL
Sure.

Paul walks by Lexie and Camille, clearing the small space in between. He turns to Camille and brushes his hand by her shoulder.

PAUL (CONT'D)
See you guys out there.

Then exits.

Lexie shuts the door behind him.

CAMILLE
Lexie, your brother's a creep.

LEXIE
I know. I grew up with him.

CAMILLE
No, I mean, he's really--I mean I think he doesn't understand boundaries or something?

LEXIE
Right. Hey, can you stop flirting with him? I'm sure that will solve whatever crisis you're having in your head right now.

Camille's brow tenses.

LEXIE (CONT'D)
I'm going to get dessert.

Lexie exits.

Camille looks down.

INT. COOPIST ZYQUIL ELEMENTARY / LYNNE FANTILE'S FIFTH GRADE CLASSROOM - DAY

MRS. LYNNE FANTILE (F, 36), a plump, direct woman, speaks out to her class of SEVENTEEN FIFTH GRADERS, seated on the CARPET.

LYNNE
Explorishuarings where exquimmermighlormorging periodsmexquimmerjuleghs noisly nampster-queerlings excumulators. Noimsgulators exquiguckulage nosegivings nimumuleg noimsulext marking period exquimumuleg noimsberg nobodulators exquimumuleg hamsburgers. Just to kind of put this all into perspective for you.

She gestures to the BOARD.

LYNNE (CONT'D)
Mister bibblewick norberuario. Mister nibblewick nosegiving. Mister exgormsberings nibbles-esque birthsgivings.

She faces the kids and leans in close.

LYNNE (CONT'D)
Now I want you to take a moment to think about what all of this was supposed to mean.

Near the back edge of the classroom carpet, Chris sits cross-legged.

Slowly, we recede into Chris's warped perspective: The events told at Coopist Zyquil through Chris's eyes obey something of a different logic than anywhere else.

Where some of his classmates sit together, buddied up, he's alone, a pale kid with awkwardly pointy features.

CHRIS (V.O.)
This is what my life is going to be for the foreseeable future? This is the best solution the adult world could come up with to allocate our time? I mean, could they really believe anyone in here is learning anything from this? I get there aren't unlimited resources for education, but it seems they could be expending *fewer* resources, and we could be learning even *more* if this system wasn't engineered to make everyone so complacently air-headed. I don't know how much longer I can sit here and silently take this.
(beat)
Drats, I think my nose is loaded with boogers again. I hate when this happens!

Chris violently strains to sniff the air.

Then he sticks his finger in his nose and digs.

LYNNE
Chris, really? That's disgusting! You know you're not supposed to pick your nose.

The students dart their eyes back to look at him.

THE OTHER STUDENTS
(unison)
Ew!

CHRIS
But I was just trying to be able to breathe again.

LYNNE
You can breathe just fine.

CHRIS
No, otherwise I wouldn't be doing this.

LYNNE
If you must pick your nose, you can go to the washroom.

Chris lifts his butt off the ground, looking toward the exit.

LYNNE (CONT'D)
But now you've burned this image into our heads of you picking your nose, and we're not going to be able to stop thinking about you picking your nose in the bathroom!

Chris sits back down, furrows his brow and wipes his face on his SHIRT.

STUWIE DENT (M, 11), a brown kid, shoots his hand into the air and speaks without waiting to be called on:

STUWIE
Ew!

LYNNE
That's right, Stuwie. Ew. Gosh, where was I?

Lynne looks back to the board.

The students all turn their heads back to face her except Stuwie who stares on at Chris.

LYNNE (CONT'D)
Ah, that's right. Excumoomulators nosegivings. Excomportulators facegivings. Nibblewick intesticulator diguwendo.

Stuwie sticks his tongue out at Chris and contorts his face around.

Chris stays looking straight ahead as though paralyzed.

Stuwie starts waving his hands around Chris's head.

Chris doesn't move a muscle.

STUWIE
(just to Chris, dropping his voice low to sound like an alien creature)
I ate your sister and mother for dinner.

Chris turns an eyeball to Stuwie.

Stuwie licks and slurps at the air.

That moment, GRACE LANIE (F, 36), a woman with a sugary sweet soprano voice pops her head in the doorway. Her FLOWERY SUNDRESS flows about her body. As she leans in, it leads the students' eyes up to her doe-eyed, symmetrical face.

GRACE
Hi! So sorry to interrupt.

LYNNE
Please, not at all!

GRACE
I'm going to bring Chris, Brianna, and Kodie to the special studies room now if that's okay.

LYNNE
Sure. Now you guys just follow Miz Lanie. Up, up. Time to go.

The three stand from different spots on the carpet and make their way to the door.

CUT TO:

INT. COOPIST ZYQUIL ELEMENTARY / SPECIAL ED ROOM - DAY

Chris blows his nose hard into a tissue.

He sits at the desk next to BRIANNA (F, 11), a shy, pale girl with freckles and KODIE (F, 12), a pretty, outspoken girl, wearing a STAR OF DAVID BRACELET.

The ROW OF THREE DESKS with their chairs attached to them are lined up at the front of the classroom.

Grace stands above them as Chris wipes the tissue off his face.

GRACE
All better?

She extends a little black TRASH CAN to him.

He pitches the tissue and nods with his entire upper body.

She stows the can back beneath the TEACHER'S LARGE DESK.

GRACE (CONT'D)
Good! Do you guys know why you're in here today?

The kids sit there for a beat.

KODIE
No.

GRACE
Okay, I thought that might have been the case. The school is getting to participate in a special research project, and we picked you guys to take part. How does that sound?

KODIE
Good.

BRIANNA
Good.

GRACE
It's gonna be a lot of fun.

Chris smiles.

GRACE (CONT'D)
We're just waiting on Mister Fabrizian to get here. He's the researcher.

MR. FABRIZIAN (M, 36) enters the room, tall, ginger, wearing THICK GLASSES and dressed a little more business than the rest of the teachers in a PRIM BUTTON-DOWN with a JACKET on and a BRIEFCASE at his side.

GRACE (CONT'D)
Speak of the devil!

Chris's smile fades.

MR. FABRIZIAN
Hi you guys! Did Grace give you the rundown?

He picks a CLIPBOARD off the desk.

CHRIS
She's Miz Lanie!

MR. FABRIZIAN
What am I saying? *Miz* Lanie. Pardon me. Where are my manners?

He chuckles and shoots her a big smile.

She beams.

MR. FABRIZIAN (CONT'D)
So, I'm just going to be asking you three some questions today. We're interested in your opinions on some pretty specific things. And well, let's just get right to it.

He seats himself and grabs a NOTEBOOK out of his BRIEFCASE.

Grace sits on the main desk, looking on at the kids from behind Mr. Fabrizian.

MR. FABRIZIAN (CONT'D)
And we'll go one by one here, so I'll pose the question, and first you'll answer,
(gesturing)
And then you'll answer, and then you'll answer.

He points to Chris.

MR. FABRIZIAN (CONT'D)
I'm going to be taking some notes here.

He clicks a PEN.

Face lights up--he pulls out his PHONE, places it on the desk, and taps the dim screen a few times.

MR. FABRIZIAN (CONT'D)
Oh, and we're recording. Cool! So the first question is, if you lived during the time of slavery, do you think you would go along with it or would you have a moral objection to it, and why? Go!

He points at Kodie, first in line.

KODIE
Um, I think I probably wouldn't go along with it because it's bad, and a lot of people didn't really have a good time with that, so I might like try to fight back or something.

He smiles to himself as he scribbles in his notes.

MR. FABRIZIAN
Okay, interesting.

Looks to Brianna.

BRIANNA
Yeah, I was kind of gonna say basically what she said. Like I wouldn't think it's cool, and I would, like, not do it basically.

MR. FABRIZIAN
Okay, nice.

He nods his head and jots something down.

Then looks up to Chris.

CHRIS
I mean, I want to say I wouldn't go along with it,

Mr. Fabrizian scribbles.

CHRIS (CONT'D)
but I understand there were a lot of social pressures back then that made it hard for people to resist and really easy to conform. I mean, the question could be made much more specific because it's like who am I if I lived back then? Am I my age and the son of slave owners? If that's my situation, I think there's a negligible chance of me lifting a finger to help the slaves.

Mr. Fabrizian stops in his tracks. Crosses something out.

CHRIS (CONT'D)
Maybe at most I'd, like, sneak them some food when I can, but you have to take into account my sphere of influence. I'm eleven years old. I can do basically nothing. I'm herded around different rooms all day and told what to do. How would I do anything to effect change? Especially of a massive social institution like the transatlantic slave trade!

Mr. Fabrizian's eyes widen. Grace covers her jaw as it drops.

MR. FABRIZIAN
Are you saying you would just..go? Along? With slavery?

CHRIS
Well, plus, maybe it benefits me. Maybe it lifts up my family, so it raises my status. Our ability to comport ourselves societally might fall apart completely without owning slaves. These are the things you have to think about when considering this kind of question. A, what's it called?

Fabrizian checks a box on his notebook: "Outlier."

Chris taps the desk a few times.

CHRIS (CONT'D)
A...question. A specific type of question. Uh...I can't think of it. Well anyways. I kind of need to blow my nose again.

MR. FABRIZIAN
Um. You girls can go back to your classroom for now. We might have you in for some more questions later.

Brianna stands up and heads for the door.

KODIE
Just walk back? Alone?

They look to Grace.

GRACE
Yeah, that's fine you guys.

Brianna and Kodie exit.

GRACE (CONT'D)
Chris, are you feeling alright?

CHRIS
Not great.

MR. FABRIZIAN
Let's keep going with the questions! If you were a Muslim living in Iraq circa nine-eleven, how would you feel about Al-Qaeda? The people who flew the planes into the buildings. You know,

Fabrizian makes a gesture of pretend planes with one hand and a tower with his other arm, colliding.

CHRIS
I know what Al-Qaeda was.

MR. FABRIZIAN
Okay, so yeah. What would you think of those kinds of people, living back then?

CHRIS
I imagine I would feel like they're one of the main groups fighting for my worldview and way of life being recognized and understood on the global stage. I may or may not have been a member of the group myself--I know it was only a tiny minority of Muslims who were--but I probably wouldn't think what they were doing was so wrong. Even if I was a strictly peaceful Muslim myself, I imagine the symbolism of bringing this western superpower to its knees would excite and amaze me at some level. Especially as an eleven-year-old muslim like I would be in that time, who maybe hasn't developed his full sense of empathy and understanding of the significance of human life.

Fabrizian scribbles in his notes at a hundred miles an hour.

MR. FABRIZIAN
Wow, real nuanced! You know, you're kind of ruining this study. Do you know that?

Grace steps closer to Fabrizian's desk and puts her hand on his back.

GRACE
Hey, it's going to be fine I'm sure. He's an interesting case study if nothing else.

Chris sinks in his chair.

That moment, Lynne waltzes in.

LYNNE
How's this whole thing going? I just sent everyone else to recess. You guys just about done?

MR. FABRIZIAN
(to Chris)
How about this? How about this, huh?! If you were born in Austria, a German boy just in time to live out your adolescence during the first world war, tried to be an artist, failed miserably, became frustrated by the hyperinflation of German fiat currency and felt your country wasn't fairly treated by the world at the resolution of this global military struggle, what would you do? Huh?!

CHRIS
I guess I would probably be Adolf Hitler, blame the jews and have six million of them killed along with millions of other minorities I don't like. Is that what you want me to say? Look, Mister Whatever-your-face-is. I'm a determinist. I believe we live in a deterministic world where some things are set into motion in a specific way and can't be changed and that's just the way they are. So if I was born Adolf Hitler, I would have been Adolf Hitler and would have done the things he did. An eleven-year-old Adolf Hitler, like myself.

Lynne throws her hands in the air.

LYNNE
He’s a monster!

She flees the room.

The three that remain sit for a beat, frozen in place where they are.

Chris SNEEZES in Fabrizian’s face.

And again! Half trying to cover it this time with his elbow.

And again!

MR. FABRIZIAN
That’s enough!

Grace brings the BOX OF TISSUES over to Chris.

He takes them.

GRACE
Give us just a sec.

She grabs his hand and pulls him out into the hallway.

INT. COOPIST ZYQUIL ELEMENTARY / SPECIAL WING HALLWAY - DAY

Grace kneels down to meet Chris at his level. He blows his nose with one hand, holding the tissues in his other.

GRACE
Why do you say things like that that are going to upset people? You knew that would upset him, right?

CHRIS
Hypothetical.

GRACE
What?

CHRIS
That was the word I was trying to think of before. A hypothetical question.

GRACE
I’m confused by you Chris.

CHRIS
And I by you.

GRACE
Huh?

CHRIS
I said, and I by you, Miz Lanie. I'm confused by you too.

GRACE
Why are you confused by me? I just want to make sure you're okay. It's my job.

CHRIS
Can I ask you a hypothetical question?

GRACE
Go ahead.

CHRIS
How would you feel if you were born into the body of a little boy circa twenty twelve and when you're in the fifth grade, you meet the most beautiful woman you've ever met in your life. And more importantly, she's sweet. She's caring. She even offers you a tissue and shows you how to blow your nose. She's not like all of the other teachers in the building...at first blush. And then she takes you into her classroom and flirts with her colleague around a project to prove that you must be stupid and naïve because you're still in grade school. And when you answer differently from how this hack colleague of hers expects, she calls you an *interesting case study*. How would that make you feel?

Grace looks down, scrunches up her face. Works to keep it blank and hidden.

GRACE
Go to recess, Chris.

He reaches down to her hand, lifts it and intertwines their fingers.

She looks up and sheds a tear.

CHRIS
Grace?

GRACE
I'm sorry.

CHRIS
But you don't have to be. Come run away with me. Do the strange, radical thing that will have you looked at weird and judged and shamed. Be the slave owner who sets his slaves free and fights for abolitionism! Be the Nazi officer who abandons his post--who defects! We can't fix the world, but we can save each other.

GRACE
Chris, you don't understand.

CHRIS
But I *do* understand, and I'm telling you, you can still be this stupid idealist who commits to the ignorant sort of answers that daft researcher was fawning over. You can still think with all the youthful naïveté of a twelve-year-old girl of average intelligence! Do it for us!

Grace cries.

GRACE
Chris, no!

Chris leans in and kisses her on the lips.

Right away, her eyes perk wide.

Fabrizian pokes his head toward the doorway.

MR. FABRIZIAN (O.S.)
Sweetie, is everything okay?

Then rounds the alcove to see the couple in plain view, heads too close together.

Grace doesn't move for a second.

MR. FABRIZIAN (CONT'D)
What's going on?

Then stands and brushes her hair away from her face.

CHRIS
We're in love you bastard!

MR. FABRIZIAN
Did this cretinous freak kiss you?

CHRIS
She could never love a ginger like you!

Fabrizian cackles maniacally.

MR. FABRIZIAN
Wow, you are really just a racist little tyke then, aren't you? That's going in your file for sure.

He lifts up his phone, still recording.

MR. FABRIZIAN (CONT'D)
It's alright. Ms. Fantile will take it from here. But since you gave such complicated answers, it'll take the rest of your recess.

He turns away to head down the hallway and grabs Grace's hand in his.

She steals a glance back at Chris, then submits to Fabrizian's motion.

Chris falls to his knees and throws up his hands.

CHRIS
No! That's not fair.

MR. FABRIZIAN
Who said anything about fair? Wasn't fair for the slaves.

CUT TO:

INT. COOPIST ZYQUIL ELEMENTARY / LYNNE FANTILE'S FIFTH GRADE CLASSROOM - DAY

Chris sits in his same carpet spot.

Lynne sits directly across from him, talking at him two inches from his face.

LYNNE
Explorishuarings where exquimmermighlormorging periodsmexquimmerjuleghs noisly nampster-queerlings excumulators.

CUT TO:

INT./EXT. SUGARTOWN STREETS / PAUL'S CAR - DAY - TRAVELING

Paul drives. Chris sits in the passenger's seat.

CHRIS
Man, I crikey hate school!

Paul pats Chris's knee reassuringly.

PAUL
Yeah, we all do.
(beat)
But did that all really happen like that?

CHRIS
Yeah!

PAUL
You kissed your Special Ed teacher after her boyfriend made you answer questions about the degree to which you would have tolerated slavery as an eleven year old in the south pre-abolition?

CHRIS
Exactly.

PAUL
Chris, cut the crap. That story doesn't make any frickin' sense.

CHRIS
Hey! You're not supposed to curse in front of me!

CUT TO:

INT. DOC KIMBALL'S HOUSE / KITCHEN - DAY

Doc stands eye-to-eye with Paul but from their stances, she may as well be towering over him.

DOC
He said you said the F word and the C word!

PAUL
He's just confused.

DOC
I wouldn't even allow that second word in this house, for Saint Pete's sake!

PAUL
Do you want me to keep driving him home from school? I feel I've been reasonably dutiful with this stuff.

DOC
Paul, he's your half-brother. Don't you want to have a meaningful relationship with him?

PAUL
I mean technically, a half brother would share half the genetic material of my parent.

DOC
I'm not going to take this slander any longer.

PAUL
Mom, no, sorry, wait. I love him, but he's eleven. I'm twenty-two. We don't have a lot in common.

DOC
Well if you don't want to have to run the awful errand of picking him up now and again, maybe you should think about getting a job.

PAUL
Right. This whole conversation was really just your opportunity to remind me of my incompetence. My insurmountable debt to you.

Paul scurries away.

DOC
Paul, don’t be like this.
(yelling after him)
Just don’t curse in front of him, please!

INT. DOC KIMBALL'S HOUSE / CHRIS’S BEDROOM - NIGHT

On Chris’s desk sits a MUSIC BOX WITH A BIRD, spinning around and making TWINKLING MUSIC.

At the edge of his bed, his NOTEBOOK and E-READER are placed together.

His notebook is opened to a SKETCH OF A HEART with “Chris + Grace” written inside of it.

His e-reader displays a page with ADVICE ABOUT PRAYING TO GOD.

Chris kneels before his bed, praying.

CHRIS
(whispering)
Please, God. I don’t know if you’re real. I don’t know if you set things into motion in a certain way where the course of events can’t be changed, but if you can do anything to alter my life, please let Miz Lanie see that we could be perfect for each other. Please let her fall in love with me. I’ve never gotten to know love before, and I feel like she’s the one I’m supposed to experience it with. She just seems so much more understanding than any of the girls in my class. Please show her I’m better than that hack researcher. And let her see that his ginger hair and complexion really is somewhat unflattering even though I’m not racist. Amen.

Chris gets in bed, and pulls the covers up.

Then grabs one of his pillows and pulls it close to his chest, so he has something to hold at night.

INT. DOC KIMBALL'S HOUSE / LEXIE'S CHILDHOOD BEDROOM - NIGHT

Paul and Lexie share a JOINT. Paul's sprawled out on the bed. Lexie is in her swivel chair, turned towards Paul.

PAUL
Chris told me a weird *crikey* story about his day at school.

LEXIE
I don't think that's how that word works.

PAUL
Yeah, whatever. I'm done having my language policed for the day.

LEXIE
What was the story?

PAUL
Something about getting pulled into guidance for some thought control experiments.

LEXIE
Poor kid.

PAUL
Well you don't think that actually happened, do you?

LEXIE
I don't know. People say grade schools have gotten pretty weird.

PAUL
Literally who says that? Republicans?

LEXIE
I don't know. Millennials definitely run shit differently than X-ers and boomers and if you told me that shit's more confusing now to a fifth grader, I'd believe you.

PAUL
Not like it was some picnic for us.

LEXIE
Right. And it’s not like Chris’s spectrum tendencies could be helping him at all.

PAUL
When do you think Mom’s going to get him diagnosed?

LEXIE
I feel like she’s more lax about that stuff now.

PAUL
Not that obsessive, insecure attachment thing we had going for a while there.

LEXIE
Maybe still have.

PAUL
You know, I used to think growing up happens because of time passing, but I’m beginning to think growing up happens because of other people judging you and deciding to do something about those judgements. And you sort of..you know, feeling the impact of that.

LEXIE
What do you know about growing up?

PAUL
Lexie, I think I have this disease.

LEXIE
Yeah?

PAUL
Yeah, every couple nights I aggressively get this urge to stay up until three in the morning, desperately trying to satisfy all my perverted fantasies.

LEXIE
That’s just called being in your twenties.

PAUL
Got it. What’s being almost thirty called?

LEXIE
Fuck off.

PAUL
Seriously, Lexie. Where’re you at? In a nonjudgemental way.

LEXIE
What does that mean?

PAUL
Like, life things.

LEXIE
Did Mom tell you to ask me?

PAUL
No, I just--

LEXIE
Because I don’t need to explain myself to her.

PAUL
She didn’t. I just care.

Lexie takes a deep breath.

LEXIE
We’re figuring things out. I think maybe Camille is my person. Maybe we do end up getting married and starting a family, but it’s early, and we both still feel so young, and I don’t want to talk all this mushy bullshit with you.

PAUL
Well, for the record, before we get off the subject, I think she’s a keeper.

LEXIE
Oh yeah, what do you like about her? Her tits?

PAUL
Whatever.

LEXIE
No for real though.

PAUL
She seems spiritually at ease with herself.

LEXIE
C'mon, you think she's hot. I noticed you two stopped flirting after you showed her the bird book. Real smooth, Paul.

PAUL
I always did like older women.

LEXIE
That's just a manifestation of your subconscious insecurity that no woman would measure up to your big sister.

PAUL
Don't be fucking weird, Lexie!

LEXIE
What were you talking about with her in the study that night anyway? For real.

PAUL
I told her I think she should marry you.

LEXIE
Oh, fuck off. For real, Paul.

PAUL
I really told her I think she should marry you.

Lexie looks at him sideways for a second.

He freezes, the joint halfway extended between them.

LEXIE
Are you stupid?

PAUL
I'm just answering--

LEXIE
No--shut up! Are you actively trying to sabotage my most serious relationship?

PAUL
I was just trying to help.

LEXIE
It’s not your fucking place!

Lexie knocks the joint out of his hand, onto the floor. Paul flinches.

LEXIE (CONT’D)
Get out! I don’t want to see you right now.

PAUL
Lexie, I’m sorry!

LEXIE
Whatever you think you know or think you were trying to do...Fuck! I’m so glad I don’t have to live with you anymore, you autistically perverted psycho.

PAUL
Goodnight, whore.

Paul exits.

Lexie taps around on her PHONE.

A RING, RING emits from the ear speaker.

PHONE VOICE
We’re sorry. The person you are trying to call has a voicemail box that has not been set up yet.

Lexie taps the screen again, then throws the phone on the ground.

She picks the joint up off the floor and lights it, aggressively hitting it once.

Then again.

INT. DOC KIMBALL’S HOUSE / PAUL’S ATTIC BEDROOM - NIGHT

Paul sits on his bed, laptop resting in his lap once again. This time, a more mature female face onscreen, PENELOPE WECKERS (F, 24). She sits in a dark room lit with a purple and green laser light. She applies makeup to her face.

PAUL
Sometimes I feel like you're the only person I can really talk to.

PENELOPE
I'm glad you feel like you can talk to me!

Paul sighs.

PENELOPE (CONT'D)
C'mon, Paul. Everything is going to be okay. Didn't you say you wanted to move out? Maybe you'd feel better if you did that.

PAUL
I don't have any money!

PENELOPE
Well, have you thought about getting a job?

PAUL
Are you gonna help me tailor my resume?

PENELOPE
Sure, I'll help!

PAUL
Okay, what are we going to put on it? I'm a bum. I've been doing nothing with my life for the past three years.

PENELOPE
I don't know. Maybe we can say you're a sexual pervert, and you can apply to work at the sex shop.

PAUL
I feel like there's been a dark cloud hanging over me all week.

PENELOPE
What's going on?

PAUL
Just shit with my stepbrother. Shit with my sister. Shit with my mom.

PENELOPE
Did I meet your stepbrother?

PAUL
Yeah, Chris. The troubled kid. He lives here now.

PENELOPE
Oh, right, the fifth grader! I was picturing someone our age.

PAUL
Sometimes he talks like he is.

PENELOPE
Yeah?

PAUL
I think he feels like we're rivals for my mother's love.

PENELOPE
Are you?

PAUL
I don't need my fucking mother's love. Penelope, I miss you! When are you gonna come by again?

PENELOPE
I do need to come by. Actually, I need my projector back.

Pauses applying her foundation.

PAUL
Oh. Okay.

PENELOPE
Just for this project I've been working on.

PAUL
Okay, yeah. It's in the basement where you set it up. You can sneak in anytime to get it. The garage code hasn't changed.

PENELOPE
Perfect.

Resumes applying her foundation.

PAUL
Actually, the main one who's been using it is Chris.

PENELOPE
Your half brother?

PAUL
Stepbrother.

PENELOPE
And you said he's not getting enough love?

PAUL
Oh, he's getting all the love there is to get. Not like I ever got.

PENELOPE
But he's not happy or something?

PAUL
He's eleven. Everyone's frustrated, nervous and scared at eleven. They just baby him more over it.

PENELOPE
I don't know. I was a pretty happy eleven-year-old.

PAUL
You're a girl. So that's kind of different.

PENELOPE
How is it different?

PAUL
Girls are treated like these precious little things. You get what you want just by asking. You haven't started getting your period yet. Life is uncomplicated.

PENELOPE
Right.

PAUL
Especially for a cute girl, and you must have been among the cutest.

Penelope laughs.

PAUL (CONT'D)
I want to do abominable things to you.

PENELOPE
You're always thinking about sex.

PAUL
I'm not always thinking about it.

PENELOPE
You don't need to get defensive. I like how much you think about it. I like how hard I make it for you to not think about it.

PAUL
I mean, I'm a guy in my twenties. Do you think I think about sex too much?

PENELOPE
I want you to use me like the dumb little whore that I am.

PAUL
I guess I think about it a lot, but I don't think about it *too much*.

PENELOPE
I've been a bad girl, and I need to be punished.

PAUL
I know guys who it's really all they think about. They can't think about anything else. They don't talk about anything else.

Penelope puts down her makeup brush and makes a pouty lip.

PENELOPE
(baby voice)
But who can be the one to put me in my place? I might just keep doing bad things if I don't get that punishment. Huh?

PAUL
Penelope, be serious! Do you think I'm a sex-obsessed moron?

PENELOPE
No.

PAUL
No?

PENELOPE
Paul, I think you're great just the way you are.

PAUL
Really?

PENELOPE
Yeah!

PAUL
You're not just saying that to make me feel better?

PENELOPE
No. I like your quirks. I like that you're utterly unmotivated at this moment in your life. I like when you flirt with the idea of trying to win the affection of other girls. And I *love* how easily your little ego bruises.

PAUL
My ego does not bruise easy!

PENELOPE
You're right. It doesn't. I was just adding that in to see if you were paying attention. Like two truths and a lie.

PAUL
Oh.

PENELOPE
You're a big, strong man with a formidable ego.

PAUL
Formidable. I like that. Formidable.

PENELOPE
Mhm. Impressively powerful.

PAUL
Penelope, you're perfect.

PENELOPE
Yeah?

PAUL
Hey, if you like me so much, why don't we start dating again?

PENELOPE
Maybe we could. I need some time to think about it.

PAUL
Aw, okay.

Paul looks down.

PAUL (CONT'D)
But I can still fuck you?

PENELOPE
My body's all yours.

PAUL
Penelope, come over!

PENELOPE
Shh, shh, shh! We have to do it right here. Right now.

PAUL
But your body's not here right now. How am I supposed to use it?

PENELOPE
It's not the same through the internet, is it?

PAUL
It never has been.

PENELOPE
Hmm. I guess you're gonna have to use your imagination.

PAUL
Okay. Can I use my voice to issue commands and shit?

PENELOPE
Of course, Daddy.

PAUL
Okay. Um..Take off your shirt.

PENELOPE
Oh my god, do you ever think about anything else other than sex?

PAUL
You’re such a..fucking tease!

PENELOPE
You have to surprise me. One of these times I lead you on, do your deep philosophizing instead of just getting self-conscious and then pushing me to be sexual.

PAUL
Don’t kink shame me! You tricked me! You insisted on going until I walked right into your little trap.

PENELOPE
I meant what I said though before. The good part.

PAUL
Wait, which part?

PENELOPE
Guess.

PAUL
Oh my god, you’re such a fucking tease. Did you know I almost cheated on you?

PENELOPE
No you did not.

PAUL
Well it wouldn’t be cheating anyway. It’s not like we’re dating.

PENELOPE
Who would be dumb enough to let you stick her cock in you?

PAUL
I almost did it with my sister’s girlfriend.

PENELOPE
You’re pathetic.

PAUL
I’m a hero!

PENELOPE
You’re fucking pathetic. You’re never going to have sex again as long as you live.

PAUL
How can you say that?

PENELOPE
Paul, you don’t listen. You think living as a girl is life on easy mode. When we were dating, you tried to cheat all the time. You’re damaged, and you’re not even looking for help.

PAUL
Help from where? My bitch psychiatrist lesbian mother fucked me up! I’m not going back to mental health services!

PENELOPE
You lash out at the universe for not rewarding you for being your loathsome cockroach self. You’re desperate for sex now? Good! Maybe a guy who’s bigger and stronger than you would consider using your asshole if you douched it out for him.

PAUL
You fucking bitch whore! You fucking cunt! I hate you! I wish you were dead! I want to stab you to death and hate fuck your whore dead body before running you over with my car!

Penelope reaches down to her groin area.

PENELOPE
Keep going! Don’t stop!

PAUL
I want to tie you up and suffocate you while letting fire ants crawl all over your body and into your asshole!

Penelope moans, moving her arm vigorously.

PENELOPE
Oh my god, Paul! Don’t stop.

PAUL
I want to burn your bloodied body at the stake while your entire family is forced to watch with metal implements that keep their eyes pried open so they see the life drain from your eyes.

Penelope moans very loudly.

PENELOPE
Oh! Oh! Oh! Oh my God. Oh my God!

Paul cries.

Penelope catches her breath.

PENELOPE (CONT’D)
Oh my god, Paul! It’s never been that good. Paul, are you okay?

PAUL
(through tears)
I don’t know what this is doing to me.

PENELOPE
Oh, but Paul, you’re helping me a tremendous deal, you know that?

Paul sobs.

PAUL
Sometimes it just feels a little too real.

PENELOPE
Yeah, it can feel really real sometimes. I know.

PAUL
Like I need someone to hold me now. I’m all broken and I just feel like such a dirty piece of shit, but you’re not here.

PENELOPE
I know, it’s hard.

PAUL
Penelope, I can't. I need a body to hold.

PENELOPE
Paul, it's going to be okay.

Paul finally breathes a few breaths without shedding tears. Wipes his face with his shirt.

PAUL
You're so chill about things, you know that?

PENELOPE
You think so?

PAUL
Yeah. Sometimes I think the world is divided into two types of people. You have the Hamlets and the Horatios. I'm a Hamlet, and you're a Horatio. You're calm. Even-handed. You think carefully about the things you say. You can always see the bigger plan. And here I am just mucking around in the dregs of shit. I mean, I'm a mess.

PENELOPE
But you're my mess.

Paul sheds another tear.

PENELOPE (CONT'D)
And with any luck, you'll fuck your sister's girlfriend soon.

PAUL
Penelope, can you come over, please?

PENELOPE
You're a danger to yourself and others, Paul.

PAUL
Can you come over, please.

PENELOPE
I need to go to sleep.

PAUL
Please.

PENELOPE
I'll see you when I get the projector.

Penelope hops off the call.

Paul stares at the faceless screen, eyes drying.

Swipes to his desktop: Molly's face stares back at him, now set as his background.

INT. UPSCALE RESTAURANT - NIGHT

SERIES OF SHOTS:

A) Dressed to the nines, DOC and ROSIE waltz through a dance space. Their DRESSES are covered in abstract designs of birds.

B) They're guided by an OSTENTATIOUS HOST to their regular spot.

C) FOOD now on the table, they cut their STEAKS and raise perfectly carved pieces to their mouths, forks poised downward in the left hand--the British way.

D) Close on Rosie's face as she chews, swallows, raises her napkin and laughs at the most hilarious joke.

E) Reverse on Doc, doing the telling.

F) Pulls out of her pocket a little box.

G) Rosie opens it to reveal a LARGE RUBY HEART NECKLACE.

H) Their hands clasp together.

Voiceover accompanies this scene with no diegetic sound:

PAUL (V.O.)
(beep noise)
Hey, Dad. It's Paul. Calling you I think it's Saturday night. I, um, just calling to say that I miss you. Yeah, um. I was thinking maybe you and me could get together sometime. Maybe get lunch. And it could just be you and me. None of the girls, you know. Those women. Those tough broads as you probably would have called them. Tough and gamey. But seriously, I'm hoping you'll hear this.
(MORE)

PAUL (V.O.) (CONT'D)
It's been too long. I know my mom invited you to dinner the other night, and that's ridiculous. I don't know why she did that, but this isn't that, and I'm not her, and I promise this isn't some ploy on her part to try to influence you. *I* just want to see you. So, um, call me back when you can. Thanks. For everything.
(line goes dead)

CUT TO:

INT. CAMILLE'S APARTMENT - DAY

Light streams in through the THIN, LIGHT CURTAINS.

Camille lies face up in bed, nude.

Lexie lies prone, next to her.

LEXIE
You're amazing.

CAMILLE
So are you.

LEXIE
Really? I'm starting to see an aging woman when I look in the mirror.

CAMILLE
What are you talking about? You're in your twenties, Lexie!

LEXIE
You're in the thick of your twenties. I'm almost not in my twenties anymore.

CAMILLE
Is someone being a little sillyhead? Is someone catastrophizing about nothing?

LEXIE
Eh, you'll get it when you're older.

CAMILLE
Now why do you have to go and make it like that?

Lexie rises from bed, stretches her arms into the air.

CAMILLE (CONT'D)
I'll bet Doc and Rosie still have a scintillating sex life in their middle ages.

LEXIE
Alright, I don't need to hear about my moms right now.

CAMILLE
I'm just saying!

LEXIE
Well, what about your parents? You think Sanjay and Nadia still fuck like jack rabbits?

CAMILLE
I think heterosexual couples slip into the boring asexual phase more easily.

LEXIE
Yeah? And why's that?

CAMILLE
Maybe it's a preservation mechanism we've held onto from our countercultural roots.

LEXIE
Our gay roots?

CAMILLE
Yeah.

LEXIE
How so?

CAMILLE
Like, we had to be a little bit hungrier and sneakier to keep the charade going. An opposite sex partner as a cover. Clandestine visitation in the dead of night.

LEXIE
Now you're starting to sound like Doc, waxing poetic about behavioral anomalies.
(beat)
She likes you, you know?

CAMILLE
Yeah?

LEXIE
My whole family seems to.

Camille's expression hangs on this for a moment.

INT. COOPIST ZYQUIL ELEMENTARY / GRACE LANIE'S OFFICE - DAY

Chris stands by the door.

Grace sits at her desk.

GRACE
Do you know why you're here, Chris?

CHRIS
No.

GRACE
You said some pretty disturbing things to me the last time we talked.

CHRIS
What was so disturbing about it?

Grace grabs a pen and begins to jot something down.

CHRIS (CONT'D)
Was it my honesty?

GRACE
Are you not happy here at Coopist Zyquil?

CHRIS
Not really, no.

GRACE
What aren't you happy about?

CHRIS
Well, you don't take me seriously for one. And you're the only girl I've met that I like.

GRACE
You don't like the girls in your class?

CHRIS
Some of them I like. But with you it's different.

GRACE
How is it different?

CHRIS
You're beautiful, and I think I love you. Can you just let me love you?

GRACE
But you see, this is where it's like not really appropriate. Do you see how I might find that upsetting to hear?

CHRIS
Upsetting? My love upsets you?

GRACE
You don't really know me, Chris.

CHRIS
I cannot control my emotions, Grace! Would you prefer I silence them?

GRACE
Okay, I'm going to ask that you don't call me by my first name.

CHRIS
How can you break my heart so callously?

GRACE
I'm a teacher. You're a student. You need to respect the boundaries I set. I'm going to have to send you back to class if you can't get off this subject.

CHRIS
I can't say I find your closed-mindedness attractive. I've always found that to be an ugly trait.

The color evaporates from Grace's face.

GRACE
But I'm not trying to be attractive.

CHRIS
You're not? Why are you wearing that lipstick? Why are you wearing that dress?

GRACE
Can we please stop talking about my appearance?

CHRIS
Because being beautiful on the inside isn't enough for you. You're vain. I guess I didn't think of that when I thought to call you beautiful. How short-sighted of me.

GRACE
Chris, you're being extremely rude.

CHRIS
You women are all the same. You cloak yourselves in costumes and wear masks of makeup. You hypergamous strumpet!

GRACE
Chris, you're scaring me!

CHRIS
Vanity thy name is woman! Haven't you yet learned that beauty is only skin deep?

GRACE
You're allowed to think your thoughts, Chris, but some things you just don't say out loud. I think you need to find someone closer in age to you to channel this energy more healthily with.

CHRIS
You're ageist just like the rest of them!

GRACE
What?!

CHRIS
You teachers make me sick. Patronizing us students all day long. Well you'll rue this day when we finally rise up and take control. There are a lot more of us than there are of you. We'll run this school soon, and I'll be king. Then you'll be sorry you didn't take me seriously, but it'll be too late. You'll beg on your knees to be my bride, but there won't even be a place for you among my harem, you disloyal bitch.

GRACE
Where did you hear that word?!

CHRIS
Bitch, slut, jizz. I know all the words, and how and when to use them.

GRACE
Stop it, Chris! I understand you're upset, and maybe you're dealing with difficult stuff at home, but that doesn't give you the right to speak to me that way.

CHRIS
The more you protest, the more bad words I'll use.

GRACE
Look, I know there's a way we can resolve this peaceably.

CHRIS
Wretched slut.

GRACE
Do you want me to write you up for a discipline referral?

CHRIS
Cum-hungry bitch.

GRACE
I'm going to call your mother right now and send you home!

CHRIS
My mother's at work! I can walk home. I know the way.

Chris shoots up and steps to the door.

GRACE
No, Chris! That's not allowed!

Grace grabs for his arm, but he breaks free.

CHRIS
Don't tell me what to do.

GRACE
Chris, come back here!

Chris runs out the door.

Grace grabs for the phone and pages the office.

GRACE (CONT'D)
(into phone)
Chris Kimball is running for the exit now! Someone get security to stop him!
(beat)
The side with the pickup circle! The west exit I think! No, the east exit! I don't know!

EXT. COOPIST ZYQUIL ELEMENTARY / PARKING CIRCLE - DAY

Chris bolts it to the street.

SIX SECURITY GUARD CLONES OF MR. FABRIZIAN tackle him to the ground.

He squirms beneath them, and they put him in handcuffs.

LYNNE (PRE-LAP)
Chris?

INT. COOPIST ZYQUIL ELEMENTARY / LYNNE FANTILE'S FIFTH GRADE CLASSROOM - DAY

Chris comes to, out of his nightmare daydream. He sits across from Lynne at a desk in the corner.

LYNNE
Chris.

Shakes his head awake.

CHRIS
Yeah?

LYNNE
They need to see you in the office.

CHRIS
Am I meeting with Miz Lanie?

LYNNE
I don’t know. You’ll have to see when you get there.

She slips a HALL PASS across the desk to him.

INT. COOPIST ZYQUIL ELEMENTARY / LONG HALL TO MAIN OFFICE - DAY

Chris paces in the direction of the main office.

He steps gingerly as though walking on thin ice. His hand trembles with the pass in it.

Finally, he approaches the door and opens it to see...

INT. COOPIST ZYQUIL ELEMENTARY / MAIN OFFICE

Mr. Fabrizian leans on the office countertop, joking with the ADMINISTRATORS at full volume.

He turns around at the sound of the door and meets Chris’s eyes.

MR. FABRIZIAN
Here he is! The man of the hour! Let’s get you back here into one of these rooms.

CUT TO:

INT. COOPIST ZYQUIL ELEMENTARY / OFFICE BACK ROOM - DAY

Fabrizian and Chris sit at a DESK across from one another.

The room around them is blank, nondescript. It’s an interrogation room.

Chris holds a hankie to his nose and blows hard.

Then wipes his nose and re-grips the hankie.

MR. FABRIZIAN
So we brought you here today--

Chris blows again, loudly interrupting Fabrizian. Then stops for a moment.

MR. FABRIZIAN (CONT'D)
So I brought you here today to try to--

Chris blows again.

Wipes his nose.

Puts the hankie in his pocket.

Fabrizian taps his foot all the while.

MR. FABRIZIAN (CONT'D)
I'm here to try to help you.

CHRIS
Okay.

MR. FABRIZIAN
You seem troubled.

CHRIS
How so?

MR. FABRIZIAN
Chris, does this audio sound familiar to you?

Fabrizian plays audio from his PHONE.

CHRIS'S PRE-RECORDED VOICE
We're in love you bastard! She could never love a ginger like you! We're in love you bastard! She could never love a ginger like you! We're in love you bastard! She could never love a ginger--

Fabrizian taps the phone screen to pause it.

CHRIS
It feels like you're blackmailing me.

MR. FABRIZIAN
I'm concerned for you, really. I wanted to give you a chance to unpack this with me if you wanted to before we call your mom and dad and see about having a conversation about this.

CHRIS
I have two moms.

MR. FABRIZIAN
What?

CHRIS
You said before you call my mom and dad, but I don't have a dad. You could call my uncle.

MR. FABRIZIAN
This is besides the point. Do you want to talk with me before we call them?

CHRIS
What is there to say?

MR. FABRIZIAN
You want to try to explain yourself? Your words? Your actions? You used some pretty strong, hateful language. I don't think I'm alone in feeling that disciplinary action might be appropriate. I mean, that's no way to talk to an adult.

CHRIS
Adults aren't always right just because they're older.

MR. FABRIZIAN
Excuse me?

CHRIS
Well, what do you want me to say?

MR. FABRIZIAN
I think an apology is in order to begin with.

Chris grits his teeth. Then swallows.

CHRIS
No, you're right. I was way out of line. I shouldn't have used those harsh words with you. I hope you can forgive me.

He looks up to Fabrizian.

His face softens.

CHRIS (CONT'D)
I've actually been reflecting on this whole situation, and I think it's a sign of my youthful naïveté. Clearly, I need to find someone closer in age to myself to explore these feelings with, and women over twenty-five should be reserved for your lot, and..I mean, I don't know how you'd stratify the age groups exactly, but...

MR. FABRIZIAN
Hey, hey. It's okay. You're trying. You're a bright kid. You don't have to have all the answers now. I think someone closer in age is the right direction to be thinking in.

CHRIS
How old is Grace anyway? Just to give me a reference of how high not to go.

MR. FABRIZIAN
She's thirty-six.

CHRIS
(truly in awe)
Wow.

MR. FABRIZIAN
Actually, I don't know why I told you that. It's none of your business.

CHRIS
It's okay, I won't tell any--

MR. FABRIZIAN
Look, I'm glad we worked this out a little. I am still supposed to call one of your parents to come get you early today.

CHRIS
Wait, what?

MR. FABRIZIAN
Yeah, we have to notify them, and we *do* have to send you home with a discipline referral.

Chris scoffs.

MR. FABRIZIAN (CONT'D)
I'm sorry. Those are the principal's rules.

CHRIS
So was my apology just inconsequential then?

MR. FABRIZIAN
Well, no. Now you get to feel better about what you did. And God knows, and he's smiling down at you, doing the right thing. And at me, getting you to do the right thing.

CHRIS
You are the devil.

MR. FABRIZIAN
What?!

CHRIS
When I first laid eyes on you, Miz Lanie said, "speak of the devil," and there you were.

MR. FABRIZIAN
That's just an expression for when someone appears who you mentioned in conversation.

CHRIS
What kind of sick fuck are you, coming and asking kids if they'd go along with slavery or foment the holocaust? Where's my apology for you wasting precious minutes of my life I'm never going to get back with your braindead research? You remorseless hack!

Fabrizian glares at Chris.

MR. FABRIZIAN
I'm not happy with you, Chris. Not happy.

Fabrizian exits with a slam of the door behind him.

Chris gets up and peeks out the window to the main office.

He steps to the door and opens it with care to not make a sound.

INT. COOPIST ZYQUIL ELEMENTARY / MAIN OFFICE - DAY

At a distance, Fabrizian stands by the office ladies, who sort papers.

MR. FABRIZIAN
I mean, he just doesn't know how to behave himself. I don't know how he's going to get on in middle school with this attitude.

Chris tiptoes to the FAR BACK DOOR.

It has BLACK AND YELLOW TAPE on it reading, "EMERGENCY EXIT! ALARM MAY SOUND!"

He opens the door with care to make as little noise as possible.

Slips out.

Shuts it carefully behind him.

EXT. COOPIST ZYQUIL ELEMENTARY / PARKING CIRCLE - DAY

No alarm. Just the harmonious hum of nature.

Birds sing in the trees. A stream rushes nearby. Freedom!

Chris paces slowly at first.

Then takes off, jogging away from the school.

Now sprinting down the street.

EXT. SUGARTOWN STREETS - DAY

Chris runs free through the neighborhood, chanting to himself:

CHRIS
(sotto)
Need a woman under thirty! Need a woman under thirty! Need a woman under thirty!

INT. DOC KIMBALL'S HOUSE / PAUL'S ATTIC BEDROOM - DAY

Paul lies in bed, asleep.

His PHONE rings loudly.

He jolts awake, looks down to the screen.

It's Mom calling. Rolls his eyes and sighs.

Slides to answer.

PAUL
Hey, Mom.

DOC
Hey, Paul, can you do me a big favor?

PAUL
Um, maybe. What's the favor?

Paul multitasks, waking his LAPTOP also laid on his bed.

Discord is open to "PusillanimousDimple69," but she hasn't messaged him since their call last night.

DOC
They're saying Chris needs to be picked up from school early today, and Rosie and I can't get away from work.

Paul punches out a new message on the keyboard as he speaks:

1:17 PM "heyy babe" - Unread

PAUL
Yeah, I was planning to pick him up like usual. I know you guys are busy.

Paul yawns.

DOC
No, Paul. You're not listening to me.
(MORE)

DOC (CONT'D)
They need someone to pick him up early, and they need like a parent or guardian to talk some stuff over with it sounds like.

PAUL
What kinds of stuff?

DOC
I don't know Paul. You're going to have to find out and report it to me later. Can I trust you with this extremely modest level of responsibility?

PAUL
Look, I know Chris is more important to you. How many ways do you have to frickin' show me? I'll pick him up from school. I'll go early. I'll go right now. Jesus!

He hangs up the phone.

Then slips into the T-SHIRT and SWEATPANTS off the ground from yesterday and exits.

A new message appears on his computer screen:

From PusillanimousDimple69, "Just freed up. I'm going to swing by and get the projector now



CUT TO:

INT./EXT. SUGARTOWN STREETS / PAUL'S CAR - DAY - TRAVELING

Paul drives like a maniac through a 25 MPH neighborhood.

PAUL
What the fuck! It's like all I am to her is a tool to serve the better upbringing of the good one. The more important child. The one she hasn't yet fucked up.

He takes a sharp turn down School Lane.

Still accelerating.

PAUL (CONT'D)
Well, I'll show her. I'm gonna be someone big and important one day. I'm gonna revolutionize some shit one day. It's always the people you least expect. I'm gonna upend industries as soon as I can manage to get out of this sodden house.

Sirens blare behind Paul.

PAUL (CONT'D)
Holy shit. Fuck, how fast was I going?

He stops short on the side of the road, tires squealing.

INT./EXT. SUGARTOWN STREETS / PAUL'S CAR - CONTINUOUS

We're just across the way from the school parking circle.

A SCHOOL POLICE OFFICER steps outside of Paul's window.

He lowers it.

OFFICER
What the fuck do you think you're doing?

PAUL
I'm sorry, officer! I was told there's some kind of accident or emergency with my younger brother at the elementary school. I was worried sick. I just had to see him and make sure he was okay.

The officer crinkles his nose at Paul.

Then SNEEZES!

CUT TO:

INT. COOPIST ZYQUIL ELEMENTARY / MAIN OFFICE - DAY

The OFFICE LADIES and Mr. Fabrizian sit behind the main office desks.

He spins around in his chair, making childlike noises and entertaining them.

MR. FABRIZIAN
Whoopie! And I was look, “oops!” He just could not stop laughing.

Paul enters.

KAREN (F, 43), the senior office lady, looks up to greet him.

KAREN
Hi. How can we help you?

PAUL
I’m Paul. I’m supposed to pick up my brother, I heard.

MR. FABRIZIAN
You know, we’re really supposed to have a parent here.

PAUL
Our moms are just a little busy. Is something wrong? I heard there maybe was an accident or an emergency?

MR. FABRIZIAN
No, no. Chris is perfectly safe. I mean, he’s just sitting in time out because he’s been..well. I guess there’s really no nice way to say it. He’s been a bad boy.

CUT TO:

EXT. DOC KIMBALL'S HOUSE - DAY

Penelope, dressed in all black, GRUNGE STREETWEAR, slips into the backyard through a hedge.

BUNNY-EAR HEADBAND, CHOKER around her neck. She looks like she’s dressed for an event.

She approaches a PORCH BACK DOOR.

Twists the knob. It won’t give.

Scampers her way around the SHRUBS to a GARAGE DOOR.

Opens the KEYPAD. Tries a code.

A RED LIGHT blinks three times.

She mouths the numbers to herself.

Presses some more buttons.

The garage door rises.

INT. COOPIST ZYQUIL ELEMENTARY / MAIN OFFICE - DAY

Fabrizian stands in the office back room, pulling out his hair.

Karen steps toward the room.

Paul and the others look on silently.

MR. FABRIZIAN
He was here just a minute ago, right?

Karen shrugs.

MR. FABRIZIAN (CONT'D)
I mean, it's either that or I'm going crazy.

Karen steps to one of the phones. Pages the building.

KAREN
(over loudspeaker)
Chris Kimball, please report to the main office. Chris Kimball, to the main office, now!

INT. DOC KIMBALL'S HOUSE / FOYER - DAY

The house is dead silent on this floor.

Penelope tiptoes around the corner, headed for the basement stairs.

She scans the KITCHEN for faces, trinkets, valuables...

Then slips down into the stairwell.

INT. COOPIST ZYQUIL ELEMENTARY / MAIN OFFICE - DAY

Fabrizian sorts through papers double quick as his face goes flush.

MR. FABRIZIAN
None of you guys sent him back to his classroom, right?

The office ladies look to one another with blank stares.

KAREN
I didn't.

Paul checks his PHONE.

MR. FABRIZIAN
Did he go to the bathroom?

Then steps closer to the desk.

PAUL
Um. Is my brother here? Because I might need to go soon.

MR. FABRIZIAN
Sir, if you could just wait a moment--!

INT. DOC KIMBALL'S HOUSE / BASEMENT - DAY

Penelope tiptoes down the stairs.

Old-timey music reverberates around the hall.

She makes it to the landing.

A PROJECTOR mounted on a post projects DW GRIFFITH'S *BIRTH OF A NATION* onto a LARGE WHITE WALL on the far side of the room.

A couch sits before the projected image, cherub head of DARK HAIR peeking above it.

PENELOPE
Paul?

She takes off her TANK TOP.

Paces toward the rear of the couch.

Drops the shirt on the ground.

PENELOPE (CONT'D)
What are you watching? Smut?

She laughs and crosses to the front of the couch.

Penelope clocks Chris, who glances over to Penelope, shirtless and then doesn't take his eyes off of her.

The moment she sees him, she reaches back for the shirt and reclothes herself.

PENELOPE (CONT'D)
Oh, sorry. You're not Paul.

CHRIS
No, it's okay.

Chris pauses the movie.

PENELOPE
Are you Chris?

CHRIS
Yeah. Who are you?

PENELOPE
Just a friend. Neighbor.

CHRIS
Are you Paul's girlfriend?

PENELOPE
No.

CHRIS
Oh. How do you know my name?

PENELOPE
He's told me about you.

CHRIS
Well, what did he say?

PENELOPE
He said you're his stepbrother.

CHRIS
He said it that neutrally? He didn't express any opinion about me?

PENELOPE
He said you're a good stepbrother. He said he thinks of you more as a half brother with how everything has gone.

CHRIS
I know he hates me. How old are you?

PENELOPE
I'm twenty-four.

Chris's eyes widen.

CHRIS
You’re not thirty.

PENELOPE
Not yet. I’m not even close to thirty. Do I look thirty?

CHRIS
I’m not good at ages yet to be honest with you. I guess you’re close to Paul’s age.

PENELOPE
Exactly. You know Paul’s not thirty, right?

CHRIS
I guess I did know that. You’re like the same age as him, but you’re really not his girlfriend?

PENELOPE
We have a different kind of arrangement.

CHRIS
What kind of arrangement?

PENELOPE
It might be something you haven’t heard of before.

CHRIS
I’m pretty well read, but if I don’t know, I would like to learn.

PENELOPE
Take a guess. Maybe you know more about relationships than I think.

CHRIS
Are you polyamorous?

PENELOPE
No.

CHRIS
Are you part of an asexual throuple?

PENELOPE
No.

CHRIS
Are you his mommy?

Penelope laughs.

PENELOPE
Close.

CHRIS
Do you want to tell me?

PENELOPE
I'm what's called a free-use girl.

Chris stares wide-eyed, hanging on her every word now.

PENELOPE (CONT'D)
You haven't heard of this?

Chris shakes his head silently.

Penelope goes on with more than a hint of irony that goes entirely over Chris's head, but she's enjoying herself tremendously and doing a good job of keeping a straight face all the while:

PENELOPE (CONT'D)
Well, basically a man can do whatever he wants to me. I'm intended for his use. I don't really have a choice in the matter, so I'm compliant. I've even come to enjoy being used. But I exist in the home to be taken and used and that's what I'm good for. When I'm not being used, I'm stored in the closet. Like a vacuum.

CHRIS
How do you mean, used?

PENELOPE
You don't know what I mean?

Chris shakes his head.

PENELOPE (CONT'D)
Huh. Maybe you're a little too young to understand.

CHRIS
I'm not too young! Everyone keeps saying that, and it's not true! There's a lot I understand.
(MORE)

CHRIS (CONT'D)
I read a lot--things the other kids don't. I know people do terrible, terrible things over the course of history, and they'll continue to, and I know that hypothetical time-traveling fifth graders can't fix that.

PENELOPE
This thing I'm talking about isn't something you understand because you read about it in a book. You understand it when you feel what I'm talking about inside of you.

CHRIS
(beat)
Oh. I understand.

PENELOPE
You do?

CHRIS
I know what you do.

Penelope laughs.

PENELOPE
What do you mean?

CHRIS
I think.
(beat)
No, I know. I want to use you.

Penelope's eyes widen.

PENELOPE
You're like ten years old!

CHRIS
I'm eleven!

Penelope laughs.

CHRIS (CONT'D)
It's not fair for you to ridicule me like this. You're not thirty!

Penelope has tears coming out of her eyes.

CHRIS (CONT'D)
Take off your shirt. You said you're a free-use girl! Now obey me, you slut!

PENELOPE
You're gonna make me pee myself.

CHRIS
Paul's girlfriend! Do as I say!

PENELOPE
I came to get my projector, Chris. Sorry to crash your party.

Penelope toggles the POWER SWITCH on the projector, and the room goes DARK.

CHRIS
Why can't this happen? Why Paul and not me?

PENELOPE
You're a kid. It's illegal.

CHRIS
It's illegal for a kid to find love?

PENELOPE
Look, I heard you're having a hard time with school and your parents, and that sucks, but love is not a real solution to life's problems. It's impossible. You meet someone you care about deeply but who drives you up a wall. Or you think you love someone and then you meet somebody else, and you want them more. Things don't stay the same so that love can just exist unbothered. You know, you only get to experience any excitement around it because things are constantly changing, and it never feels certain or expected. You can love the changes and the possibility without being in love with someone. You're going to have to learn that eventually. Better to start now.

CHRIS
But when am I gonna get any?

PENELOPE
It will happen in time.

CHRIS
Can it be with you?

Penelope coils the power cables around in her hands.

CHRIS (CONT'D)
Can you please take your shirt off again?

PENELOPE
I'm not allowed to do anything like that for you.

CHRIS
Could I do something to you?

PENELOPE
I would have to stop you. I'm stronger than you.

CHRIS
What if you were tied down?

PENELOPE
Now there's an idea.

CHRIS
Really?

PENELOPE
Chris, you're adorable.

She turns to leave, heads for the stairs.

PENELOPE (CONT'D)
Give me a call when you turn eighteen.

CHRIS
That's so long from now.

PENELOPE
It'll be here before you know it.

CHRIS
Okay, are you going to give me your number?

Penelope stops.

Chris grabs his NOTEBOOK.

PENELOPE
You can't tell Paul we had this conversation.

CHRIS
I won't.
(beat)
Come back here.

Penelope returns silently.

CHRIS (CONT'D)
You can write it here.

She jots something down.

CHRIS (CONT'D)
Penelope.

PENELOPE
Mhm.

CHRIS
That's a pretty name.

PENELOPE
Now you're talking more like a gentleman.

CHRIS
Kiss it.

Penelope leans down and kisses the notebook marking, leaving a BLACK LIPSTICK STAIN.

CHRIS (CONT'D)
Good girl.

INT. ZACK'S LAKE HOUSE BAR AND GRILL - NIGHT

Lexie and Camille sit at a BOOTH together, exchanging smiles.

LEXIE
I'm so lucky I have you.

CAMILLE
It looks like our food's here!

A WAITER (M, 27) approaches holding a PLATE OF CHICKEN WINGS, and a BOWL OF TOFU STIR-FRY.

Sets the wings before Lexie and the tofu before Camille.

WAITER
Enjoy! And let me know if I can get you anything else.

CAMILLE
Thank you!

The waiter walks off.

LEXIE
Camille, I just want to say again, I'm so sorry about Paul and his ridiculousness and me not understanding at our house. I know we already talked about it, but he can be just such an idiot at times, and you shouldn't have had to deal with that, and I should have listened to you.

CAMILLE
Lexie, it's totally fine. I'm past it. It's just now we know for the future.

LEXIE
Okay. It--it lifts such a weight for me to hear you say that because I was just completely out of line. It wasn't right for me to be so dismissive, but I guess at the time I didn't really know what sort of faux pas he was capable of. And it is just his autism, but he'll-- He'll learn. I'll make sure of it.

CAMILLE
No, I get it. He's differently-abled, and in some ways that maybe gives him a genius brain or some way to see things the rest of us can't, but it hinders him socially, and I can understand that.

LEXIE
Exactly, you get it.

CAMILLE
But, Lexie, I think we should give him some grace and stop talking about what he did in such a negative light because I actually think he got one thing right.

LEXIE
Oh--what?

CAMILLE
Yeah, I. I think it was hard for me to see it, but I know you. I know who you are at this point, and--I know that I love you. And I think your brother was right that if one of us was going to propose, it would have to be me. I've always been the more assertive, decisive one. I've always been the initiator, and I think that maybe I am supposed to ask you to marry me.

Lexie bites her lip.

CAMILLE (CONT'D)
'Cause it's not gonna happen otherwise, right?

LEXIE
Are you asking me to marry you?

CAMILLE
I'm, like, open to it if you are.

LEXIE
Camille, that's not how you ask someone to marry you.

CAMILLE
Well, I was just thinking because you couldn't be the one to ask no matter what, so it's like how else--

LEXIE
What are you talking about? Literally what are you talking about? Since when have I been the indecisive, waffling dingus you're describing. I'm not like my brother. I actually get off my ass and have a job and do shit.

CAMILLE
No, I just meant like--

LEXIE
I earn money. If I was going to propose to someone, I would take some of that money and purchase a proposal ring.
(MORE)

LEXIE (CONT'D)
It wouldn't have to be the fanciest thing in the world, but I would make an effort to make the moment special. I wouldn't say, "I guess I want to marry you."

CAMILLE
That's not what I'm saying at all. No, I want to marry you, Lexie! I love you. I mean, do you really care about those superficial appearance layers. C'mon. We're in our twenties.

LEXIE
That doesn't mean we can't afford things to sometimes make actually special moments. And I'm an adult woman. I'm almost thirty.

CAMILLE
I guess if that element is that important to you, I must have misjudged you.

LEXIE
Are you calling me high-maintenance?

CAMILLE
You're belittling me for what I learned was a normal way to share your love with someone! I know people who got married unceremoniously with no money, and they're some of the happiest people in the longest-lasting relationships I know!

LEXIE
Just call me high-maintenance if that's what you're saying!

CAMILLE
I'm not fucking calling you high-maintenance! You don't listen.

LEXIE
I'm hearing every word you're saying to me! Just because I don't like it all doesn't mean I don't listen!

CAMILLE
You know, I thought we had what it takes to be happy together, but now I'm not so sure.

LEXIE
I'm gonna throw up.

Lexie runs to the bathroom.

Camille sets down her fork.

Sits there.

INT./EXT. COOPIST ZYQUIL ELEMENTARY / PARKING CIRCLE / PAUL'S CAR - DAY

Rain thuds heavy on the windshield. The sky is dreary and overcast.

Paul stares at the Discord app on his PHONE.

Where his text feed with Penelope used to be is a BIG BANNER: "THIS USER HAS BLOCKED YOU."

He taps around on his phone screen, and a dial tone rings over the car's bluetooth.

CAR SPEAKER
We're sorry, the voicemail box has not been set up yet. Please try again later.

PAUL
Fuck! Penelope, why?!

INT. COOPIST ZYQUIL ELEMENTARY / SPECIAL WING HALLWAY - DAY

Chris stares through Ms. Lanie's classroom window, his E-READER in his hand, hanging by his side.

It displays a page from *Meditations on a Deterministic Universe*: "Things just happen in a certain way because of the design of things, and this cannot be prevented."

Through the window, Mr. Fabrizian is visible, shimmying up to Ms. Lanie, sat on her desk.

She pulls away, swatting his hands, laughing and smiling.

Then, he holds her close. She submits, leans forward into his kiss.

Chris sheds a single tear.

INT./EXT. COOPIST ZYQUIL ELEMENTARY / PARKING CIRCLE / PAUL'S CAR - DAY

Paul taps around on the phone screen some more. Calls “Dad.”

It RINGS, RINGS, RINGS.

CAR SPEAKER
The person you are trying to call is not available. Please leave a voicemail at the tone.

Chris knocks on the window, outside the car.

Paul hangs up and unlocks the door.

Chris gets into the passenger’s seat and shuts the car door.

CHRIS
Thanks.

PAUL
Buckle up.

Chris obeys.

PAUL (CONT’D)
I thought this was going to be another one of those days I come to pick you up and you’re not even here.

CHRIS
Oh. No I’m here.

PAUL
Yeah, no shit, Sherlock.

Paul accelerates out of the parking circle, taking the usual route home.

INT./EXT. SUGARTOWN STREETS / PAUL’S CAR - CONTINUOUS - TRAVELING

Chris pulls out his notebook, and writes something down.

PAUL
Are you gonna get me in trouble for cursing again.

CHRIS
No. Cursing's actually kind of fun.

Chris looks down.

CHRIS (CONT'D)
What's wrong, Paul?

PAUL
You know the projector you like to watch movies on?

CHRIS
Yeah.

PAUL
It's gone.

CHRIS
Oh. Yeah. But you almost never used it. Why do you care?

PAUL
I don't.

CHRIS
Oh.
(beat)
Why is it gone?

PAUL
I don't want to talk about this with you.

CHRIS
But why not?

PAUL
I was borrowing it from a friend, and they needed it back, okay?

CHRIS
But you got free use of it for a good long while.

PAUL
Huh?

CHRIS
I'm just saying, it was nice of them to let you use it in that way for some time. Even if it wasn't gonna be forever.

Paul sighs.

CHRIS (CONT'D)
No, I'm sorry. That fucking sucks, man. And sometimes you just need to get that out, and you don't need some kid who doesn't know shit about shit explaining to you why it's actually not so bad.

PAUL
Where did you hear that?

CHRIS
I'm just figuring it out bit by bit. Seeing how you judge me and figuring it out.

PAUL
You're a smart kid, Chris. You're not too bad. Just don't go skipping school yet. It's early days. Save that for when you really need it in high school.

CHRIS
Got it.

PAUL
Even if they're bombarding you with stupid bullshit.

CHRIS
See, you get it.

Paul lets out a small chuckle.

CHRIS (CONT'D)
Paul, do you believe in God?

PAUL
No.

CHRIS
Me neither.

PAUL
God is just what people tell themselves because they want to feel not alone even when they are alone. It's a stupid crutch. Or they're using it to control other people.

CHRIS
Yeah. I think that's what I feel. I'm a determinist in any case.

PAUL
Yeah?

CHRIS
Yeah. But I guess I didn't choose to think that because it was predetermined.

PAUL
What I could never work out with determinism is if we don't really have free will, how can we justify passing moral judgement on people for the things they do? Like my dad hasn't been very in touch since the divorce, but is he choosing that? Lexie always told me it was his fault, and he was a shitty father, but as more time passed, I started to think it was Doc's fault with how possessive of us she was. Like maybe he couldn't help it. That redirected my anger toward her, but maybe she couldn't help it either. Maybe we don't choose our actions at all. How can I be mad at them if they didn't choose any of it? Because I am. Because it feels like his fault. And her fault, and I'm weary of this world that seems not to care if I'm in it or not.

CHRIS
I don't know. Maybe we're predetermined to pass judgement. Maybe you were predetermined to feel that way about your dad and then your mom.
(beat)
I think the ways we aren't loved right by our family fucks us up just right for experiencing love in the world. Chides us into seeking what we need.

PAUL
Maybe. But how would you know?

CHRIS
I guess I’m guessing. Quoting books I’ve read that helped make this make sense to me.

PAUL
I think you’re right.

CHRIS
Thanks.
(beat)
Paul?

PAUL
Yeah, Chris?

CHRIS
I’m sorry nobody cares that you exist.

Chris hugs his NOTEBOOK close to his chest.

PAUL
Thanks, Chris. Me too.

INT. DOC KIMBALL'S HOUSE / FOYER / KITCHEN - LATER

Paul and Chris hang their COATS.

Doc stands in the kitchen.

DOC
Good that you guys made it back out of that storm! It looks terrible out there.

Chris wipes his boots and waddles into the kitchen.

CHRIS
Paul’s a good driver! He would never let anything happen.

DOC
Well I don’t know about that.

Paul looks like he’s gotten hit by a bus. He starts up the stairs.

DOC (CONT’D)
No, wait! Paul, come over here. There’s some pretty tremendous news I’m sure you haven’t heard.

Paul paces in, looking at the ground.

PAUL
Yeah?

DOC
So it sounds like your sister and Camille are getting married.

Paul looks up, expressionless.

CUT TO:

INT. DOC KIMBALL'S HOUSE / PAUL'S ATTIC BEDROOM - NIGHT

Rain patters on the roof still.

Paul dials his PHONE. It rings, rings, rings.

The line goes dead.

He tries again.

PAUL
(PRE-LAP)
Penelope! What the fuck, Penelope?!

CUT TO:

Paul looks through old SNAPCHAT PICTURES and VIDEOS.

PAUL (CONT'D)
(sobbing)
Penelope, what am I going to do without you?

He rubs his dick vigorously.

Then stops.

He swipes to his desktop: now a MOSAIC COLLAGE of the Molly screenshot, repeating itself in psychedelic designs.

He opens his computer. Discord is already open. A CACHED COPY OF MESSAGES remains on the screen. He scrolls through them for a second.

They vanish.

PAUL (CONT'D)
Fuck!

Paul opens up a new browser tab and types into the search engine “Role Call.”

Clicks the first result.

He clicks on the “18+ Chat” button.

The website prompts him to input a display name.

He types: “LF Molly”

START.

A live feed skipping through men masturbating.

SKIP, SKIP, SKIP...

Color begins to fade from Paul’s room and his computer screen as the video of strangers starts to blur together.

Occasionally young women will appear onscreen for no more than a mere second before skipping.

Paul stutters brief, incoherent ad-libs to try to get someone’s attention.

The soundscape becomes an otherworldly mix of SIRENS and SUSPENSEFUL ORCHESTRAL NOISE as we hear bits and pieces of “Role Call” conversations in the background.

PAUL (V.O.)
Oh, yeah, I’m looking for this girl I met last week. Her name was Molly I think.
(beat)
Yeah I’m looking for Molly.

STRANGER 1 (V.O.)
I don’t know no fucking Molly.

PAUL (V.O.)
Yeah, she has brown hair, blue eyes. Have you seen her on this thread tonight?

STRANGER 2 (V.O.)
Fuck off, pal.

We see a flash of another user’s display name onscreen: it’s also, “LF Molly.”

STRANGER 3 (V.O.)
You’re looking for Molly too?!

PAUL (V.O.)
Do you know this person?

STRANGER 3 (V.O.)
I know a Molly. She just turned eighteen today.

PAUL (V.O.)
Oh, no, my Molly turned eighteen last week.

STRANGER 3 (V.O.)
Dude, she's playing you for a fucking fool. You're gonna catch a case.

PAUL (V.O.)
What? No! What are you talking about?

STRANGER 2
She says that to every guy. She doesn't know what day it is.

MOLLY'S BROTHER (V.O.)
What are you doing with my sister on the internet, you freak?!

PAUL (V.O.)
What?! I didn't do anything.

MOLLY'S BROTHER (V.O.)
How old are you even anyway?

PAUL (V.O.)
I'm twenty.

Paul's voice starts to distort and deepen, the sounds getting twisted up in a way that sounds painful.

PAUL (V.O.)
I'm twenty-two. No!--twenty-two. No!--twenty-five.

MOLLY'S BROTHER (V.O.)
She's sixteen, you sick pervert! That's illegal! You're corrupting a minor.

AGENT OF THE STATE (V.O.)
We're copying down your IP address and reporting it to the national authorities.

CHRIS HANSEN (V.O.)
Why don't you take a seat over there?

Paul screams out in pain.

The music turns from suspenseful to tragic, melodrama.

STRANGER 2 (V.O.)
Oh, you're looking for Molly too? I just met her today. She told me she turned eighteen just yesterday. Ready to sink my teeth into some fresh meat.

STRANGER 1 (V.O.)
Oh, you know Molly too?

STRANGER 3 (V.O.)
You have to be careful because some of these girls on the internet, you don't really know how old they are.

STRANGER 2 (V.O.)
That's one of the dangers of being a weirdo who hides out on the internet all day.

MOLLY'S BROTHER (V.O.)
You sick, sick pervert! You can't tell the difference between sixteen?!

STRANGER 1 (V.O.)
That's so funny, I just met her the other day.

MOLLY'S BROTHER (V.O.)
You can't tell the difference between a fourteen year old--

STRANGER 1 (V.O.)
We had the best conversation about
(distorted)
DICK SUCKING CLUB

MOLLY'S BROTHER (V.O.)
--and an eighteen year old!?

Without resolving, the music yields to these final lines of V.O. Remnants of soundscape continue to echo.

CHRIS HANSEN (V.O.)
Why don't you have a seat?

STRANGER 1 (V.O.)
(echoing)
And hide out on the internet all day. Hide out on the internet all day. Hide out on the internet all day.

Back with Paul in real time.

His eyes are bloodshot, and sweat is dried to his face.

On his screen:

Naked dude--SKIP, naked dude--SKIP, naked dude--SKIP.

All color is gone now.

Naked dude--SKIP, naked dude--SKIP, naked dude--SKIP.

This must be purgatory.

His click of the escape button slows--a metronome running out of potential energy as the last remnants of musical soundscape fade.

Slows, slows, slows to a full stop.

Paul rests his weary eyelids down and we

FADE TO BLACK.

Five (5) second interval.

OVER BLACK:

MOLLY (V.O.)
What are you doing, silly? I'm right here.

INT. MOLLY'S ROOM - DAY

MOLLY x's out of an open "Role Call" tab on her LAPTOP.

In the next tab over, she scrolls through a GOOGLE DOCS MOOD BOARD of SCREENSHOTS OF TWENTY-SOMETHING GUYS from Role Call--pages and pages of guys like Paul she's collected.

Then closes the screen down, slips the thin metal slab into her blue and white FLORAL POTTERY BARN BACKPACK.

Her bed is filled with BIRD STUFFED ANIMALS. Pastel colors fill the room from the light BLUE of her COMFORTER to the pink of the walls and light yellow of the carpet.

She walks to the window and draws the blinds.

At a distance, a HAPPY BIRTHDAY BALLOON floats around in the wind, tied to the mailbox outside.

She grips at her skirt and struggles to suppress a smile like she possesses the greatest secret known to man.

CUT TO:

INT. JIM BIBBONS HIGH SCHOOL / OFFICE CONFERENCE ROOM - DAY

JADE (who we have known as Molly up to this point) slouches in a swivel chair. She's in a palpably different persona-- deflated. No choker. Jeans replace her skirt from before.

A SUITED ADMINISTRATOR (M, 57) sits next to her and the school psychologist, MR. GRANSCHEME (M, 52) across from her at this LONG OVAL TABLE. Everything about the room is grey, nondescript.

At the far the end of the table sits an open CHUNKY SCHOOL LAPTOP with a ZOOM WINDOW through which JADE'S PARENTS enter the conversation of the scene: ALICIA and HENRY ALLISON.

In some ways, it's Coopist Zyquil all over again but a more grown-up, drab version. Nothing about Jade's view into the scene warps our perception. On the contrary, we're getting what feels like mumblecore-like dry objectivity. Emphasis on **dry.**

GRANSCHEME
Look, all we're saying is she might need some accommodations, and we want to provide the right accommodations for her.

HENRY
Are you saying she's slow? My daughter isn't slow--

ALICIA
--That's not what he's saying.

HENRY
He's literally saying she's too slow to finish her tests on time and she *needs* accommodations!

GRANSCHEME
No, it's not like she's always necessarily demonstrated a need.
(MORE)

GRANSCHEME (CONT'D)
I mean, there are some classes here she's performing really well in. But she might be entitled to accommodations because of her condition.

SUITED ADMINISTRATOR
Think of it like, right now, some of the other kids have an advantage over her because of her condition, and we're trying to level the playing field for the rest of this year and into her junior year so she can get into the colleges she deserves.

HENRY
Look! First of all, our daughter was not conditioned! If anyone conditioned her, you guys did! So I take umbrage with your use of that, that term, sir!

SUITED ADMINISTRATOR
No, not conditioned--

HENRY
But you're trying to label her like she is! You're gonna say she is!
(ad-libbed ranting)

ALICIA
Wait, hold on a second! I need to ask something. Jade, Jade!
(to Henry, still ranting)
Okay, stop it, honey!

ALICIA (CONT'D)
Jade, what do you feel? Do you want these accommodations?

Everyone looks to her.

She looks up from hiding her glance in her phone screen on her lap.

JADE
I don't know. I don't really...care?

A beat of awkward silence as she bites and licks her lower lip--a nervous tic.

ALICIA
You--I--she doesn't mean that. You've been always a very dedicated student. I remember in the fifth grade--

CUT TO:

INT. JIM BIBBONS HIGH SCHOOL / CAFETERIA - DAY

Jade sits on the fringe of a GROUP OF GIRLS at a LONG RECTANGULAR FOLDING TABLE.

A GROUP OF BOYS sits adjacent to them a little further down, smiling, winking and leering occasionally across the way.

The queen bee of the girls, VANESSA (16) lifts her PHONE SCREEN for some of the other girls to see.

VANESSA
Look, this thing that Brad sent in the group chat is so funny!

CLAIRE (16) double-taps on the screen.

CLAIRE
Oh my god. Wait, that's actually, like, embarrassing.

Several girls scoff and titter with laughter.

Jade cranes her neck to try to see.

JADE
What is it?

VANESSA
Nothing. It's just stupid.

CLAIRE
Let her see.

Vanessa passes her phone.

On it is an UPPER TEXT, LOWER TEXT MEME with a badly-lit picture of DENNIS (15) looking messy at a party with a beer in his hand. The text says: "DENNIS; CAN ONLY GET WITH OVERWEIGHT BRUNETTES."

Jade stares, motionless for a second.

JADE
That's kind of mean.

VANESSA
I doubt he, like, actually cares.

JADE
No, I mean, he took me to prom. I feel like this is about me.

CLAIRE
No, obviously they're not talking about you. They're just saying he can only get with overweight brunettes. That doesn't mean you're overweight. You guys just went to prom as friends, right?

JADE
I mean, yeah, but still.

VANESSA
Can I have my phone back?

Jade hands it back to Claire, who hands it back to Vanessa.

VANESSA (CONT'D)
Anyway, aren't you guys excited for when my family gets the new pool put in? This summer's gonna be lit--

CUT TO:

INT. FRIENDLY'S / KITCHEN & FOUNTAIN LINE - NIGHT

Jade stands behind an ice cream counter, scooping some CHOCOLATE ICE CREAM into a GOBLET DISH. Garnishes it with WHIPPED CREAM and a CHERRY.

Meanwhile, her manager JONATHAN (M, 25) chats up one of the servers, CHLOE (F, 20), pinning her against the wall of the prep cook area.

JONATHAN
But that's the thing. If you want the dough to bake into a perfect crust, like one of my crusts, you've gotta use double-zero flour. I'm telling you--

Chloe laughs.

Finishing the sundae, Jade places it on a SERVER'S TRAY.

JADE
Chloe, ticket fifty-two is ready!

JONATHAN
Oh, ticket fifty-two?

JADE
Yeah.

JONATHAN
It's ready? We were actually about to take our smoke break. Can you just bring it out, Jade?

JADE
Which table is it, again?

JONATHAN
You're a big girl, Jade. I believe in you.

He grabs Chloe's hand and leads her out the back of the restaurant; she giggles.

INT. FRIENDLY'S / TABLE SIXTEEN - NIGHT

Jade approaches with the server's tray bearing the sundae.

Two of the same boys from her school lunch table: NICO and DENNIS.

JADE
Hey.

DENNIS
Jade!

JADE
Hi, Dennis.

DENNIS
Looking good today!

NICO
Alright, it's enough. You're freaking her out.

JADE
Did you guys know I worked here or something?

DENNIS
No. Well--

NICO
He did.

Dennis blushes. Kicks Nico under the table.

JADE
Nice. Who ordered the chocolate sundae?

DENNIS
Was it chocolate? I thought I ordered vanilla.

NICO
You said chocolate, dude.

DENNIS
I thought I said vanilla! You know what? Could we just actually not have the sundae and get the check instead?

JADE
I'll let your server know in a minute.

INT. FRIENDLY'S / KITCHEN & FOUNTAIN LINE - NIGHT

Jade crouches behind the ice cream counter, eating the unwanted sundae.

INT. JADE ALLISON'S HOUSE / KITCHEN - NIGHT

Jade enters wearing her backpack and work clothes. She glances at a NOTE by a TINY RAINBOW BOX on the COUNTERTOP: "Happy Birthday, Jade! We are so very proud of you."

She opens the box.

In it is a CUPCAKE with a big **17** in frosting painted on the top.

She eats the icing off the top.

INT. JADE ALLISON / MOLLY'S ROOM - NIGHT

Jade sheds her bag, removes her shoes and starts to strip.

SERIES OF SHOTS - "BECOMING MOLLY:"

A) Jade's day clothes dropping to the floor.

B) Pulling on black school-girl tights.

C) A pastel blue skirt atop it.

D) Makeup in her bathroom mirror: blush, eye-liner--
imperfectly like she's still practicing how to do it right.

E) In the mirror, she pulls at her belly fat. There's nothing even remotely excessive about it: a little baby fat.

F) She opens the lid of the toilet and crouches over it. We hold on her thrusting two fingers deep into her throat until the brown sludge comes up, covering the toilet bowl.

G) Back at her desk, with bloodshot eyes, smudged makeup, and some visibly broken blood vessels in her face, she opens her computer, types Role Call in the browser and clicks "START."

THE END